THRONE OF ASHES

Volume 1: The Cursed Playmate

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CHAPTER 1

The Wish Beneath the Cherry Blossoms

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They say gods don't make mistakes.

I've had a lot of time to think about that line since, mostly at night, on a reed mat, in a palace where most people would prefer me dead by the end of the week. I've decided it's true, which is worse. A mistake you could appeal.

What I asked for was to be ten again.

What I got was a rope on my wrists, a hall full of gold, and a king younger than me deciding whether I'd see the morning.

But that's later. First there was a Tuesday, and a tree.

◆

JAPAN. SPRING. A TUESDAY.

My parents were obsessed with history.

I mean that as a diagnosis, not a compliment. Other kids' fathers had a team. Mine had a dynasty. The Eighteenth, which he'd tell you was the greatest run of rulers any country has produced, and then he'd tell you why, and you'd miss your train. My mother was quieter about it, but she was the one who taped the chart over my bed when

I was six: every king of the dynasty, and in her small handwriting, the year each one took the throne and the year he died. She didn't think a child needed the middle part.

I'm eighteen now and I still can't see the number nineteen without thinking *that's how old he was.*

That's the kind of house it was. It burned down three years ago, in March, at about two in the morning. Somebody poured something through the letter slot and lit it. The police said *arson* on the first day and *ongoing* for about a year after that, and then they stopped saying anything.

I was the one who got out.

◆

The cherry road is not the fast way to school. It's the way you take if you don't want to see anyone from your class before the bell, and it costs you nine minutes. I timed it, the spring after the fire, when I needed to be in charge of one small thing.

I take it every day. Nine minutes is cheap.

The trees are old, and they lean in from both sides until the lane is a tunnel, and in the first week of April the tunnel is pink and the pavement is pink and the gutters are pink. It rained last night, and the petals have glued themselves to the wet concrete.

My phone buzzes in my blazer pocket. I don't take it out. The class chat, counting down to the entrance exams. And Soren. My twin brother writes on the first of every month from Osaka, where he lives with the uncle who offered to take me too and was visibly relieved when I said no. This month's message begins *It's three years on Sunday*, and that's all the preview shows, and that's all I've read.

Thirty-one steps from the corner to the first lamppost. I don't count on purpose anymore. It just happens.

My reflection keeps pace with me along the puddles. Black uniform, black hair that wants cutting, and a white line through the left eyebrow where a foil snapped at a tournament when I was twelve. I stood at the mirror a long time that night, feeling lucky.

I'm not sure I've felt it since. I'd have to check.

◆

"You're early."

Mrs. Hayashi runs the tea shop at the top of the slope and sweeps in front of it every morning, as if the petals were a private matter between her and the trees. The broom is taller than she is.

"Couldn't sleep," I say.

She props the broom against the wall and wipes her hands on her apron, which is what she does before saying something she's rehearsed. "Your mother's books came. The order from Kyoto. Six volumes. I had them put in my name, after. I didn't know what else to do with the account."

Six books my mother ordered in February, three years ago, and talked about at dinner. I can't remember a single title, because I was fifteen and it was dinner.

I take out my wallet. There's one note in it, a ten-thousand-yen bill folded in half and in half again, which I've carried since New Year for a reason I've forgotten.

"How much was it?"

"Put that away. After school. You'll carry them home in a bag, not in the rain like a lunatic. Go."

I put the bill in the breast pocket of my blazer, over my heart, where I'll feel it and remember, and bow, and go on down the slope.

Behind me the broom starts again. It has a rhythm like someone breathing in their sleep.

◆

The oldest tree is halfway down.

It's twice the girth of the others, and its roots have come up through the pavement and split around a little stone shrine the size of a mailbox, with a door sealed in grey mortar before anyone alive can remember. Over the door there's a mark: a circle with one line through it, straight down from the top. I used to think it was a clock face with the hands gone.

Mrs. Hayashi sweeps the shrine too. I asked her why once and she said, "Somebody should."

Every morning the old tree drops the same low branch across the pavement. I step over it.

Across the lane, a knot of kids from the elementary school are racing to the corner, yellow caps bobbing. The smallest, a boy of nine or ten, is trying to catch petals in his mouth and failing, because he's laughing too hard to close it.

He's wearing a blue shirt with red sleeves.

I had that shirt. My mother bought it in a museum gift shop the summer I turned ten, the trip where my father stood me in front of the gold mask and said, "He was king when he was your age, Kael. Nine. Think about that." I thought about it so hard I had a nightmare.

The boy trips, sits down hard on the wet pavement, and laughs even louder, head back, with his whole body.

I'd give a great deal, right now, to laugh like that about anything.

They go round the corner and the lane is quiet, and my phone buzzes again, and I'm so tired of being the one who's left that I say it out loud without quite deciding to.

"I wish I was ten again. Life was so much simpler."

The petals stop falling.

All of them. A few thousand points of pink hanging in the air between me and the trees, the way a photograph hangs. One is a hand's width from my face. I can see the little notch at the end of it.

I think, very clearly: *that isn't how anything works.*

CRACK.

It comes up through the soles of my shoes. The shrine's mortar splits with a sound like a knuckle. The roots lift the pavement in a slab, and the oldest tree on the cherry road tears loose from the ground and leans. Slow at first.

Then not slow.

I see it coming. Every coach I ever had said that about me, that I see the attack before it starts.

Seeing it is not the same as moving.

Of course, I think. *Of course it's this one.*

The trunk comes down. It doesn't hurt. It's just weight, an impossible amount of it, and the smell of wet bark, and a long way off, up the hill, the sound of a broom stopping.

Somewhere under me, my phone is still buzzing.

Then it's not.

NOWHERE. NO TIME.

I come to on my back with grit between my teeth.

There's no sand on the cherry road, so before I open my eyes I already know I'm not on it. I lie there and check my body one piece at a time. Toes. Knees. The ribs, which should be flat. The spine, which should be a story doctors tell each other later.

Everything answers. Nothing hurts. I'd have preferred pain. Pain means a hospital.

The sky has no colour. Not dark, not light; the colour of the inside of your eyelids, without a sun or a seam. Under it, to the horizon, there are dunes.

I pick up a handful of the sand and let it run, and halfway through I stop, because it isn't sand. I'm holding a hairpin. A baby tooth. A key for a lock that's long since been changed. The whole dune is made of things, worn down to grains, and bigger things poke out of it the way bones do in a real desert: a bicycle with the chain off, a dog's leash with no dog. In a dip just below me a wedding ring catches the no-light, and while I'm looking at it, it goes. It doesn't sink. It fades, like a photograph left in a shop window, until there's only the dip.

Three metres off, half buried, is a pair of reading glasses with the left arm mended with tape.

I know that tape. I did it. I was eleven and he wore them taped for four years out of a stubbornness I've since recognised in myself.

I don't pick them up. I'm afraid they'll fade while I'm holding them.

◆

"You died, Kael."

He's sitting on the crest of the next dune, where a second ago there was only dune, like a man on a wall waiting for a bus that stopped running years ago. I say *he*. He's tall and narrow and wrapped in something pale, and he's made of dust, the kind that turns in a shaft of sun through a dirty window, gold and never still. There's a face. It keeps almost arriving.

His voice is dry and not loud.

"The tree was older than you. Roots like that go a long way. It fell. That's all it was."

"Who are you?"

"Whoever you like. People have been very creative." A hand, or the idea of one, takes in the dunes. "This is mine. Everything that's

finished. Somebody has to keep it."

"The past."

"If you need a job title." He follows my eye to the ring-shaped dip. "That's what it looks like, from this side, when the last person who remembers something stops. You'd be surprised how quiet it is."

I should be screaming. There's a part of me doing it, a long way down. But the part on top sat in a police station at four in the morning answering questions about accelerants while a woman in a cardigan kept offering me a juice box, and learned that if you go cold enough you can get through nearly anything, and pay for it later.

So I go cold.

"If I'm dead, why are we talking?"

"Because you asked me for something. You stood on my step and said it out loud." He tilts his almost-head. "The little house under the tree. The old woman sweeps it, which I appreciate more than she knows."

The shrine. The circle with the line through it.

"I wasn't talking to you. People *say* that."

"*I wish I was ten again. Life was so much simpler.*" He gives it back in my own voice, and it sounds like whining. "You said it on my step at an hour when I happened to be listening. I've decided to say yes."

"You can't."

"Then you should be more careful where you stand."

There's an hourglass in his hand that wasn't there before. Clouded glass, a frame of dark wood worn pale at the corners, and sand inside the same gold as him.

"You'll be a child. Ten, since you were specific. Somewhere that's finished; I'll choose where. Two years." He turns it over, and a grain lets go with a sound I've never heard anywhere else. *Tick.* "Two floods

of the river. When the second one goes down, I take my hand off you, and you go back exactly where you were."

On my back under eighty years of cherry tree, with my phone going.

"You're lending me two years and then sending me back to die."

"You're already dead. That part's done." He says it kindly, which I don't forgive him for. "I'm lending you some time I happen to have. It isn't really mine to lend. Try not to waste it."

"And if I don't want it."

He doesn't answer. The sand keeps falling.

◆

"Then tell me the rules."

My hands have started to shake. I put them under my arms so he won't see.

"They'll understand you, and you'll understand them. It'll feel like talking through a wall, and they'll hear the wall." He counts it off on dust fingers, like a landlord going through a lease. "You keep what you carried nearest your heart. Nothing else."

"Why me?"

He goes quiet. Somewhere behind me a dune sighs, a thousand small forgotten things settling. He looks past me, down the slope, at the glasses with the taped arm.

Then he says, in my mother's voice, exactly, the pitch and the catch in it and all:

"*Don't let them forget his name.*"

I'm on my feet. I don't remember getting there.

"She said it to me first," he says, in his own voice. "On the grass. She was more polite about it than you've been."

"Whose name? *Whose?* What did she—"

"Simple?" the god says, and the dust finally manages a mouth, and it's smiling. "We shall see."

The dune behind him lifts. A wall of gold grains rising into that colourless sky and bending toward me, and I get one breath, and it's full of other people's lost things.

Then it's on me, and I'm going down, and I'm going *in*. My sleeves swallow my hands. Something is folding me up like a letter, shorter and shorter, and the blazer is a tent and then it isn't anywhere, and the last sound is small and patient and very close to my ear.

Tick.

Light. White, flat, enormous light, and heat with it, and a smell so thick it has texture.

Fish. Smoke. River.

THEBES. MIDDAY.

The heat has its hand on the back of my neck before I've opened my eyes.

I'm lying in a slot between two walls of mud brick, under a strip of sky so blue I've only seen it on paint charts. I sit up, and the ground is very close to my face.

That's not a figure of speech. My knees are right there, and they're the wrong knees. Round, scabbed on the left, bare under faded shorts. Above the shorts, a blue shirt with red sleeves, and a label inside the collar scratching the exact place on my neck it used to scratch when I was ten.

I'd forgotten the label. The body hadn't.

My hands are a child's. Short fingers, no calluses, a bitten thumbnail I stopped biting at thirteen. The bracelet my mother wove for me, red once, now the colour of rust, hangs slack on my wrist and turns around the bone when I move.

You keep what you carried nearest your heart.

There's paper in the breast pocket. A ten-thousand-yen note, folded in half and in half again. The old man printed on it looks back with the expression of someone who has also been having a strange morning.

"Okay," I say, to see.

A little boy's voice. Clear and high, and so exactly like a recording of myself at ten that my skin crawls.

I stand, which takes two tries, because my balance is sitting forty centimetres lower than I keep it, and walk toward the noise.

◆

The noise is a market, and the market is the biggest thing I've ever stood at the edge of.

Linen awnings on poles, hundreds of them, sloping down a long dusty square to a river so wide the far bank is a line. Past the river, a strip of green so bright it hurts; past the green, desert; past the desert, a wall of pale cliff. I've seen those cliffs in a hundred photographs taken from the air. I've never seen them from the wrong side.

Upriver, behind a wall as high as an apartment block, stands an obelisk with its tip sheathed in gold, throwing the sun back like a signal. The textbooks had it grey and pitted. Nobody told me it was ever this.

My mother would have used the old name for the city, because she didn't believe in letting the Greeks have the last word. *Waset.* The city of Amun. So the river is the Nile, and this is Thebes, and the god in the dunes wasn't exaggerating when he said he'd choose.

A fly lands on my cheek. I brush it off and another takes its place. Nothing in any book prepares you for the flies.

◆

A market is mostly knees when you're this high. Boys my size run between the stalls with their heads shaved except for one braid over the right ear, which I've seen on tomb walls a thousand times and never once on a living kid.

The shouting turns into words without my noticing when. A man with fish on wet leaves swears they were swimming at dawn. Every word reaches me a half-beat late and lands heavy, like it was thrown.

The bread is what finds me. Under a stained awning a thick-armed woman is lifting flat loaves off the side of a clay oven with her bare fingers, and beside her on the counter stands a wide blue-glazed jar, cracked down one side and brimming with water.

The counter comes to my chest. My stomach makes a noise it hasn't made since I was small, because this body has never eaten, not once, and would like to start.

I lean on the counter and look into the jar to see how bad I look.

A child looks back.

Round face. Soft chin. Skin that's never seen a sun like this one. Hair falling over the forehead in rough yellow pieces, actually yellow, the colour of wheat in a museum painting.

The eyes are blue. My eyes have always been brown.

There's one thing in the water I recognise. A white nick through the left eyebrow.

I hold on to the counter and look at the stranger with my scar until the water settles and the stranger looks steadily back.

They see a child, I think. *Fine. So do I.*

"You're putting your fingers in my water."

The woman. Flour to the elbows, a cat tattooed on the inside of one wrist.

"I'm sorry." My voice is a little bell. "One loaf, please."

Her face changes, the way you'd look at a goat if it said *please.* "Where's your mother?"

"I'm on my own."

"What've you got, then?"

Barter. There are no coins here; nobody's thought of them yet. I have no grain, no linen, no copper, and I'm so hungry my hands are shaking, and there's a very small, very stupid voice in me that is ten years old and says *money is money. Show her.*

I unfold the bill and hold it up.

◆

She holds it to the light and turns it over. The old man in his high collar looks up at her, and her mouth goes tight.

"Whose face is this? He's got no crown. What's this writing?"

Nobody knows what the writing is, and they all come anyway, because that's how a crowd works: one person points and twenty come to see what the pointing is for.

"Not papyrus."

"Look at *him.* Look at his hair."

"*Khat-su,*" somebody says. It means sand-foreign. From the way he says it, it means *trash the wind blew in.*

"Spy," says somebody else, and that one travels. *Hatti. They've got yellow-haired ones up there. They send children now. Who looks at a child?*

"I'm not a spy," I say, and nobody hears, because it's the voice of a ten-year-old and there are thirty people talking.

Over the heads come two long staves, held upright, and under them two shaved heads and two spotless white kilts. Not soldiers. Not police. The granary with the ram-headed seals on its jars is thirty metres away, and these are the men who guard the god's grain.

The bread woman is already holding my bill out to them.

That's mine, I think, uselessly.

The first stave comes down, and I'm not under it.

◆

Nine years of fencing, and all it's good for in this body is knowing which way to fall.

I go low, because I'm already low. At the top of the wharf steps a cart lies on its side with its axle snapped, the broken end sticking out at shin height. I shove it as I pass, and it swings across the gap behind me, and there's a sound like a sack of onions hitting the ground and a great deal of swearing.

The second man comes round the cart from the other side. There's nothing past me but the edge of the wharf and the drop.

I go off the edge, and the mud takes me to the knees. Cold, black, stinking of everything the river has ever been fed. When I lift my head there's a soldier standing in the shallows a few metres off with his kilt hitched round his thighs, rinsing mud off his shins, who has stopped rinsing to look at me.

My right hand goes to my hip, where a sword has never been, and finds shorts.

I try the one thing I know anyway. Weight back, feint left, go right. My feet don't come out of the mud. He doesn't even step. He collects me by the front of my shirt the way you'd collect a bag someone threw at you, holds me out at arm's length while I kick, and looks up at the top of the wall, where two white kilts have appeared.

"Yours?"

"Temple's. He stole from the god's market."

"He paid with the Hittite's writing," the soldier says, as if correcting a child. "Enemy writing goes to the palace. Go back to your

grain."

The temple men look at each other. Then they go back to their grain.

That's a whole lesson, and I've just had it hanging in the air by my shirt.

The spear butt in the stomach is almost an afterthought. This body folds around it like a wet towel, and the air goes out of me so completely I think it isn't coming back.

"Stay," he says, like you'd say it to a dog, and goes for the rope.

◆

They tie my wrists and walk me back up through the market, and I'll say this for being arrested in a crowd: it's a good way to see who's who.

The soldier steps aside for a man in long white linen with a leopard skin over one shoulder, the small dead face lolling at his hip, and drops his eyes, and the priest doesn't trouble to notice. At the granary gate a scribe marks every sack that goes in, every sack carries the same ram's head, and the man standing over him is in white.

Whoever owns the grain, my father used to say, *owns Egypt. Everything else is theatre.*

Nobody looks at me. They look at the rope. A boy on a rope is a story they already know.

They see a child. I keep saying it, like a hand on a rail. *A child is nothing, and nothing is the safest thing in this city to be.*

At the far end of the market there's a boat. The soldier sets me down among the ropes, and we push off, and the city slides back behind us. Ahead, past the green, there's a long low palace of painted

columns, built at the lip of the desert, on the side of the river where the Egyptians put their dead.

The sun is going down behind the cliffs. They turn the colour of a peach.

Somewhere behind them, in a dry valley with a road snaking into it, every king on my mother's chart is lying in the dark.

The one I'm being taken to isn't there yet.

THE PALACE. LATE AFTERNOON.

The soldier doesn't bother with the ladder.

The cell is a square pit cut into rock under some back corner of the palace, with a wooden grate across the top. He holds me out over the hole the way you'd hold a bag over a bin, and lets go. It's about three metres. I land on my hip and my shoulder and the side of my head, in that order, and the grate bangs shut while I'm still finding out which part hurts most.

I am, I notice in a distant way, crying. This body does it without consulting me, hot and steady and without a sound.

Soren, I think. Sunday was going to be three years, and now I'm not going to go in a way I can't take back.

"That's a long way to fall, for someone so small."

There's a man sitting against the far wall with his knees drawn up. Old, seventy at least, thin, with the grey stubble of a shaved scalp that's been let go for a day or two. His hands are loose in his lap, untied.

"I didn't see you," I say. My voice comes out formal. It does that when I'm frightened.

His eyebrows go up. "You talk like a scribe's grandfather."

"I was raised by old people."

He laughs, dry and kind. "What did you do, grandfather?"

"I tried to buy bread. With the wrong thing."

He laughs again, and has to wipe his eyes, and I see that he's been crying too and is better at hiding it.

"And you?"

"I asked a question. An order came down under the king's seal, taking the river gangs out of my district and giving them to the god's house for the building, in the month the dykes must be cut. So I went to the hall, and I knelt, and I asked the Lord of the Two Lands whether it was his own word."

"That's all?"

"You'd be surprised what *all* costs, in there."

He didn't ask if the order was fair, I think. *He asked who wrote it.*

"What happens now?"

"Now they weigh my heart." He says it the way you'd say it's going to rain. "And after, somebody goes to my tomb with a chisel and takes my name off the wall, so the gods can't find me when I call." A small old man's shrug. "That's the real death, grandfather. Not the blade. Being nobody's to remember."

Don't let them forget his name.

I don't say anything. There isn't anything.

"I taught him to ride," the old man says after a while, not to me. "The boy. He was six. His hands were good on the reins. I told him so, and he was so pleased he told the whole court."

I sit down beside him, and neither of us says another word until a gong sounds above us, one slow note.

◆

Two palace men bring us up together, along a colonnade where servants flatten themselves against the wall and keep their eyes on the floor, through cedar doors so tall they have smaller doors cut into them for ordinary use.

Then the hall.

Two rows of columns as thick as the cherry tree march away into lamplight, each painted as a bundle of lotus stems with the flowers opening at the top, and over the flowers a gold ceiling with the smoke of a hundred lamps hanging under it in sheets of myrrh. Men stand between the columns, dozens, in white linen and gold collars and heavy black wigs, and every one of them turns his head as we come in.

The floor is painted. That's what gets me. Somebody plastered this whole floor and painted a marsh on it, blue water and bending reeds and ducks going up out of the papyrus with their wings wide, and I'm walking across it on a rope with river mud between my toes.

A hand lands on the back of my neck and puts me down on it.

"Smell the earth before the Lord of the Two Lands."

My nose is on a painted duck.

◆

A staff hits the stone three times. A herald reads out titles, a great many, and then the names that go in the ovals, and the throne name comes first, and it's one I can see in my mother's writing with my eyes shut.

Nebkheperure.

I stop breathing. My father's hand on my shoulder in front of the glass. *He was your age, Kael.* And the other date, at the bottom of the box.

They take the old man forward first. He goes on his knees at the foot of the dais, and I can see him along the floor, and his hands are shaking now. They weren't in the pit.

"The fan-bearer on the king's right," says a voice I haven't heard yet, "asked this hall whether the king's seal was the king's word."

The voice is soft. Soft and deep and perfectly polite, like a host at dinner, and it doesn't need to be loud, because the whole hall has already leaned toward it. I understand before I've seen the man that this is what everyone else in the room is arranged around.

"He asked the Lord of the Two Lands, to his face, whether the Lord of the Two Lands is lying." A pause with nothing hurried in it. "Order before mercy. Weigh him."

A priest comes out from between the columns with a balance, two little pans on chains, and sets it on the painted water. A white feather in one pan. From the same box, a red stone roughly carved into the shape of a heart, in the other.

The Weighing of the Heart. In every tomb painting I've ever studied, it happens to the dead. Nobody in this room is dead yet.

The stone goes down. There's no trick that I can see, and that's the trick: nobody here is waiting to find out what the scale says, only for it to say it, so that it was the god and not them.

The priest's eyes go to the soft-voiced man before he speaks. Just for a second.

"Heavy. The heart is heavy with disorder."

"Ammit take it," the columns murmur. "Ammit take it."

The old man looks up the steps of the dais, past the soft voice, at whoever is sitting above it, and says, clearly, in the voice you'd use to remind a child of a promise:

"Nebkheperure. I held your reins."

Two guards take him under the arms. He doesn't fight them. He's seventy and he carried a feather behind kings for a living and he knows exactly where this ends, and he lets them walk him, and he looks back over his shoulder the whole way, until the shadow between the columns takes him.

The sound is wet, and heavy, and once.

A girl comes out of the same shadow with a bucket and a rag and starts on the floor. The rag going back and forth is the only sound in the hall, and nobody is in any hurry to cover it.

An hour ago he was telling me about a boy with good hands on the reins.

◆

"The foreigner."

I'm hauled up onto my knees. The soldier from the river bows to the man at the throne's left hand. "Commander Nakhtmin. Taken at the god's market. He paid for bread with this."

He holds up my bill by one corner, stained brown with mud, and the market's words go round again. *Cipher. Hittite. Look at his hair. A child's the perfect spy.*

"Majesty." A heavy man with a heavier collar bows until his wig nearly brushes the painted reeds. "A foreigner taken inside the city with the enemy's writing in his hand. Let his heart be weighed."

"Let his heart be weighed," say the columns.

The priest hasn't even reset the balance. He steps back to it and puts his hand on the bar.

I count without wanting to. Eleven men between me and the doors, and I couldn't outrun one of them. The guards who took the old man are coming back out of the shadow, wiping their hands.

The soft voice says nothing. I look for it now. He stands at the throne's right hand, the tallest man in the room and the thinnest, so thin the indigo robe hangs off him like it's on a hook, gold thread all over it spelling the god's name, Amun, over and over. Three scars on each cheekbone, too even to be an accident. His hands are wrapped in strips of linen, like a man with burns, and over the linen he wears more rings than fingers. The eyes are light, nearly gold in the lamps,

and they move round the room resting nowhere, the way a man reads a page he's read before.

"The Vizier," someone whispers near my shoulder. "Amenhotep."

I go through the chart, twice, fast. There's a God's Father called Ay, who I'd have expected to be standing exactly where this man is standing. There's a general. There are viziers somewhere in the small print, and I don't have their names.

Either my parents were wrong, or this is a man history forgot to write down. And I just watched what happens to people who get written down.

At the throne's other hand stands the Commander, broad, with a curved bronze sword at his hip, a scar along the jaw, and eyes that look about forty. He hasn't moved since I came in.

Think. What does a child have that a man doesn't? Not pity; you watched pity leave. Not mercy; mercy got its heart weighed.

"I'm not a spy."

It rings. That's the trouble with this voice: it's a bell, and the hall was built to carry one. And it comes out wrong, the sentences too built, the words too old, out of a face with the softness still in it. A little boy who's swallowed a scribe.

"I came from very far away. I was robbed on the road, and that paper is all I have, and I would never—"

The hand on my neck hits me across the back of the head, hard enough that the hall goes white and comes back.

"You don't speak before the king unless the king bids you."

But it isn't the slap the room is reacting to. It's the voice. Two men step back from me. And the Vizier's light eyes have stopped going round the room and settled, for the first time, on me.

I lift my head anyway. There's nowhere else to put it.

The throne is gold, lion-armed, lion-footed, winged in blue and red stone. It's the one from the glass case. It was built for a god, and the boy sitting in it doesn't fill the seat.

He's nine. I've known he was nine since I was six. A narrow, serious face under the striped nemes and the gold cobra rearing off his brow. Somebody has tied a braided false beard to his chin on a cord that's rubbed him red under the jaw. His feet don't reach the footstool. They hang above it in small gold sandals, and the footstool is painted with a row of foreigners on their faces, arms bound behind them, so that when the king's feet do reach, they'll rest on his enemies.

On his collar there's a scarab of black stone. His fingers are closed around it so hard the knuckles have gone pale.

He isn't looking at me. He's looking at the Vizier, with the look of every kid in every classroom I've sat in: watching the teacher's face to find out what the answer is going to be.

He didn't give the order. The old man was right. And the boy knows it, and he sat there, with the man who taught him to ride being scrubbed off the floor in front of him.

The priest's hand tightens on the bar.

The king of Egypt turns his head, as if someone has said his name, and looks down the steps, and finds a muddy foreign boy on his knees looking straight back up at him.

Neither of us looks away. His eyes are dark and ringed with black paint and much too tired for nine, and for a long moment he just looks, the way you'd catch your own reflection in a shop window and not be sure, for a second, that it's you.

Then his fingers come off the scarab.

The king raises one hand. Not high. Palm out, off the lion's head on the arm of the throne, the way you'd ask to go to the bathroom in a

classroom where asking was frowned on.

The priest stops with his hand on the scale. Sixty grown men in gold collars hold the same half-breath, and every one of them lets his eyes slide off the raised hand and down the steps to the foot of the dais, to find out what it means.

The Vizier doesn't look up. His face is pleasant and interested, like a man watching a child try to open a jar.

"Wait," the king says.

The voice is high and thin and shouldn't carry. It carries. It wobbles.

"Majesty." The heavy man bows again. "The weighing is the law. A foreigner with the enemy's—"

"I heard."

The way a child says *I heard* when he's been told to put his shoes on for the third time.

"Bring him up."

◆

The hand on my neck walks me forward until I'm standing at the bottom of the steps with the painted footstool at the level of my eyes.

Up close he's smaller still. His wrists are sticks inside the gold. Under the kohl there are shadows, the kind you get from lying awake. He smells of myrrh and, under it, of something ordinary and warm, bread or milk, a little boy's smell.

He looks down at me from the throne of Egypt, and I look back, and I don't lower my eyes. I should. Three years of offices and interviews say drop them, be small, be sorry. But I'm already small. And I've just about run out of sorry.

Then he says, clearly, pitched to reach the back of the hall:

"I shall sentence you."

The priest's hand comes off the scale.

"By my royal authority, I declare you to be my royal playmate. And pet."

◆

For a second nobody gets it, me included.

Then the hall gets it, and the sound it makes isn't loud, courtiers don't shout, but it goes down the columns like something spilled. Shock. Disgust. Two short laughs, strangled off behind hands.

The heavy man has gone red to the wig. "Majesty, with respect. The boy is a foreigner. Possibly a sorcerer. He cannot simply be *kept*, like a—"

"He is mine now."

"Majesty, the weighing—"

"Pharaoh has sentenced."

The voice breaks clean in half on *Pharaoh*. His hand has gone back to the black scarab and shut on it, and I can see from here that it's shaking.

He's nine years old and he's terrified and he's doing it anyway, and I feel something I haven't felt since I was fifteen and watching my own house burn, which is that I would like, very much, to put myself between somebody and a thing.

He can't stop the weighing; everyone in this room knows he isn't allowed. So he's found the one sentence a king can pass that nobody can carry out with a knife, because you can't execute the king's property.

That isn't a child's trick. That's a lawyer's.

The silence after *Pharaoh has sentenced* goes on long enough to hurt. Every face in the hall turns, not fast, to the foot of the dais.

The Vizier lets the boy's hand shake on the scarab one more time. Then he bows, and it's a lovely thing, the staff dipping, the rings going down in a wave.

"The Lord of the Two Lands has spoken," he says softly, to the room, "and his word is the seal. A toy for the king. Order before mercy, but a toy costs the Two Lands nothing."

He hasn't said a word to me, and he doesn't now. But as he comes up out of the bow his eyes come to me and stay, and narrow a little, the way a man's do when the print is small and he's decided it's worth reading.

I know what it looks like when an adult sees a kid. This isn't it.

Noted, I think. *I've been noted.*

The scribe at the foot of the steps holds up my bill, and the Vizier takes it between two linen-wrapped fingers and looks at the old man's face on it for exactly as long as he looked at mine.

"Enter it, and keep it with the records of this hall. Things from nowhere should be kept where they can be found again."

The scribe lays my ten thousand yen in a cedar box and shuts the lid. The last piece of the world I came from, and it was the Vizier who decided where it went.

"Nakhtmin."

The Commander comes down the steps and stands over me.

"Cut the rope."

"It will be done."

There's nothing in the voice. The curved sword comes out and goes down between my wrists before I've seen him draw, and the cord falls in two pieces, and I felt the bronze go by. It didn't touch skin. He was never going to let it.

That was a measurement, I think. *He wanted to know if I'd flinch.*

◆

The far doors bang.

A man comes in between the columns at a run that's become a stagger, grey with dust from hair to feet. He goes down on his face at the edge of the lamplight and gets his message out before the herald has drawn breath.

"Majesty. From the north. The men of Hatti have come down again. Another city that sent tribute to Kemet has opened its gates to them, and its prince has sworn to their king. The road past it is shut."

The hall comes apart. *Hatti again. That's the third this year. Send the army. There's no army to send; the god's house has had it all for the building. You'd take from Amun?*

The Vizier lifts his staff a hand's width, and it stops.

"The council will hear the messenger. Privately. The king is tired."

Nobody asks the king if he's tired.

I've stopped listening. My mother's chart is unrolling itself down the wall over my bed, with all her small notes in the margins.

Letters from the vassal kings, begging for archers. Nobody sends archers.

The stela this boy puts up in the temple, with his own name on it. "If an army was sent to Djahy to widen the borders of Egypt, it had no success."

I know this. Not the day, or the city, or the name of the prince who just changed sides. But I know which way this reign leans, because I was raised by two people who had read the end of it, and I know the number at the bottom of the box.

Sixty men in this room are shouting about what happens next, and not one of them knows.

I do.

A child can't hold a sword, I think, and my hands have started shaking again, and it isn't fear this time. *A child can't sit on the council, or ask who wrote the order. But a child who knows what's coming—*

—would be worth keeping. For a while.

◆

"Come here."

It's very quiet. It's for me. Nobody is watching the steps. I go up two, three, until I'm beside the painted footstool, and the king of Egypt leans down off his father's throne until his face is near mine.

"What are you called?"

"Kael."

He tries it. "Kael." Carefully, like a word in somebody else's language, and the sound of it goes through me, because it's the first time anyone in this whole world has said my name.

Then, lower: "Do you know senet?"

"No."

"Good." His eyes go, for half a second, to the Vizier's back, and come back to me. "Learn slowly."

That's all. He sits back, and the tired, frightened, nine-year-old face closes like a box and goes polite and empty.

I stand on the step with that in my ears.

He wants a playmate who loses. A playmate who loses is harmless, and nobody troubles to take a harmless thing away from a child. He's just told me how to stay alive, in front of all of them, and not one of them heard it, because who listens to a little boy asking his toy if it can play a game.

I came up those steps thinking I'd found the one other person in the room as trapped as me. I was right. I just hadn't thought through

what a trapped thing learns to do.

◆

The soldier from the river takes me out. He doesn't drag me. He walks, and I follow, because I'm property now, and that's what property does.

As we pass between the columns, a man in a wig leans to the man beside him and says, not very quietly, "The Pharaoh's toy." The other one laughs into his hand.

I count. A hundred and twelve paces, two turns, three steps down into a corridor where the plaster is bare and the air smells of lamp oil and old bread. Servants' rooms. Close enough to the hall to be sent for.

He pushes a cedar door open with his foot. A room as narrow as a man's arms spread. A reed mat, a clay bowl of water, a window slit high up with the last of the light coming through it red and lying across the mat like a cut.

He shoves me in, not hard, and I sit down on the mat, because my legs have decided.

There's something under the edge of the mat. A sandal. A child's, leather, small enough that it wouldn't go on my foot now, which is saying something. One of a pair.

I look up. The soldier is still in the doorway, watching me hold it. He's young, I see now. Twenty, maybe. Not cruel. Just someone who stopped expecting things to go well a while ago.

"That one lasted eleven days," he says.

He pulls the door shut. A bar goes across it, on the outside.

◆

I sit on the mat in the dark with the sandal in my lap.

The red bar of light climbs the wall and goes purple and goes out. Somewhere above me the gong sounds again, and when it's gone I can hear my own breathing, which is small and fast and belongs to a child. There's myrrh in my hair and river on my skin and under it, I swear, faint, old smoke. From the house.

Eleven days.

Learn slowly.

Somewhere in this palace a man with linen on his fingers has decided which box I belong in. Somewhere a nine-year-old is lying in a bed built for his father, deciding, with his eyes open, how long his new toy is likely to last.

And somewhere a long way off, where nothing is, a man made of dust is watching a very small hourglass.

Tick.

I put my knees up and my arms round them. They're very small knees.

I think about the boy on the cherry road, on his backside on the wet pavement in his blue shirt, laughing with his head back.

I think about my own voice under the tree, saying it to nobody.

I wished for a simpler life…

…and the gods gave me a palace full of people who want me dead.

◆ ◆ ◆

END OF CHAPTER 1

Next: Chapter 2 · The Shield of the Pharaoh